KCE PATHWAYS · GRADES 4–5 · UNIT 3: BUILDING THINGS · WEEK 11 · READING

The Night the Calf Came Early: Punctuating Dialogue — Teacher Lesson Plan & Answer Key

Learning objectives: Students punctuate dialogue correctly (quotation marks, commas with tags before and after, capitals, end marks inside quotes, a new paragraph for each speaker) and explain how dialogue shows character and moves the plot. They connect this to Unit 2 by spotting character change and viewpoint through what characters say.

Duration: 35–45 minutes
Materials: Computer or tablet with the lesson open · pencil · printed Pre & Post sheet

Lesson flow (as it appears on screen)

1. Slide 0 · Intro and name capture: the student types first and last name so results go to KingCretot Experience. Preview the story and the quest list.
2. Slide 1 · Warm-Up Review (Unit 2): two quick items on character change, viewpoints, author's purpose, and text structure/synthesizing. Point out that dialogue is a great place to see change and viewpoint.
3. Slide 2 · Pencil Break (Pre): the student completes the Pre-Lesson Warm-Up sheet on paper before any teaching.
4. Slide 3 · Picture It: The Rules of Dialogue. Walk through the labeled diagram (tag first vs. tag last) and the 7-rule chart. Have the student point to each comma and quotation mark and say where it goes. Stress: commas and end marks go INSIDE the closing quote; a tag after the quote stays lowercase (she said).
5. Slide 4 · Vocabulary flip cards: dialogue, quotation marks, dialogue tag, speaker, narrative, strong tag.
6. Slide 5 · Vocabulary practice: one multiple-choice item and one typed item.
7. Slide 6 · Story Part 1 (paragraphs 1–4) with a barn scene illustration, plus one comprehension item. Encourage reading the dialogue aloud in each character's voice.
8. Slide 7 · Story Part 2 (paragraphs 5–8) plus one comprehension item. Ask: how is Nadia different at the end?
9. Slide 8 · Dialogue Does Two Jobs: shows character and moves the plot, with a Unit 2 link (character change and viewpoint through dialogue). Two items.
10. Slide 9 · Punctuation Detective: one find-the-mistake item and one which-explanation-is-correct item. Have the student explain WHY the wrong choices are wrong.
11. Slide 10 · Fix the Sentence (4 typed items): dialogue punctuation, capitalization, comma placement, plus one its/it's or run-on item. Checked exactly (curly or straight quotes and extra spaces are OK). The corrected sentence appears after the 2nd miss.
12. Slide 11 · Punctuate the Conversation (1 typed item): the student retypes an unpunctuated line from the story with capitals, comma, quotation marks and end marks.
13. Slide 12 · Match-Up Round: 5 term/meaning pairs, 2 points per first-try match.
14. Slide 13 · Speed Trail (bonus XP only): 3 quick dialogue questions against the student's own best time.
15. Slide 14 · Boss Challenge: two two-step items (spot ALL the mistakes / choose the correct conversation or explanation).
16. Slide 15 · Pencil Break (Post): the student completes the Post-Lesson Challenge sheet, including the dialogue-writing item.
17. Slide 16 · Results: score out of 100, sent to KingCretot Experience. 85+ shows the Dialogue Pro congratulations with a big confetti burst; below 85 shows encouragement and a fresh question set on the next try.

Lesson answer key with reasoning

Every scored item the student sees, in order, across all three rotating question sets. The "why" is the same reasoning shown on screen after a second missed try.

WARM-UP REVIEW (UNIT 2) (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
rv1_s0	At the start of a story, Leo hides behind his mom at swim lessons. At the end, he dives in first and cheers on his friends. What does this show?	**Character change: Leo goes from scared to confident**	Leo is scared at the start and confident at the end. A difference between the start and the end is character change (Week 6).
rv2_s0	A writer explains how milk gets from a cow to the grocery store, using the words “first,” “next,” and “finally.” Which text structure is this?	**Sequence**	“First, next, finally” are signal words for sequence, which puts steps in time order (Week 9).
rv1_s1	Malia thinks the class should get a hamster because it teaches responsibility. Theo thinks a hamster would be lonely all weekend. What are you comparing?	**Two viewpoints on the same topic**	Malia and Theo see the same topic in different ways, so you are comparing two viewpoints (Week 7).
rv2_s1	A newspaper piece says, “Everyone should vote YES to build the new dog park!” What is the author’s main purpose?	**To persuade**	The writer is trying to get readers to vote a certain way. Trying to change what readers think or do is persuading (Week 8).
rv1_s2	At the start of a story, Priya says, “I’ll never be good at fractions.” Which ending detail is the best EVIDENCE that Priya has changed?	**Priya says, “Let me try the hard one first.”**	Asking to try the hard problem first shows new confidence. It contrasts directly with her words at the start, which is evidence of character change.
rv2_s2	Source A explains why bees are disappearing. Source B describes how one town planted flowers to help them. Combining both into one answer is called ___.	**Synthesizing**	Putting ideas from more than one source together into one bigger understanding is synthesizing (Week 9).

VOCABULARY PRACTICE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
v1_s0	The words characters say to each other in a story are called ___.	**Dialogue**	Characters’ spoken words are dialogue.
v2_s0	Type your answer: words like “Nadia said” that tell who is speaking are called a dialogue ___.	**tag**	The words that tell who is speaking are the dialogue tag.
v1_s1	The marks that go around a speaker’s EXACT words are called ___.	**Quotation marks**	Quotation marks go around the exact words a character says.
v2_s1	Type your answer: the character who is talking is called the ___.	**speaker**	The character who is talking is the speaker.
v1_s2	Which word is a STRONG dialogue tag verb, one that tells HOW something was said?	**whispered**	“Whispered” tells the reader how the words were said: quietly. “Said” is a plain tag, and “calf” and “snowy” are not verbs.
v2_s2	Type your answer: a story that tells about events, usually with characters, is called a ___.	**narrative**	A story that tells about events with characters is a narrative.

STORY PART 1 (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
p1_s0	Why does Grandpa think the calf is coming tonight?	**Clover is pacing in her stall**	In paragraph 1, Grandpa says, “Clover is pacing in her stall,” and then, “I think her calf is coming tonight.”
p1_s1	In paragraph 2, how does Nadia’s dialogue show that she is surprised?	**She asks “Tonight?” and ends her next sentence with an exclamation point**	The question “Tonight?” and the exclamation point in “two more weeks!” show her surprise through punctuation.
p1_s2	What does Grandpa mean when he says, “Calves don’t read calendars”?	**Calves can be born earlier than expected**	Nadia said Clover wasn’t due for two weeks. Grandpa jokes that a calf doesn’t follow a due date, so it can come early.

STORY PART 2 (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
p2_s0	How does Grandpa feel in paragraph 7, and which dialogue tag shows it?	**Excited: he “called” it out**	When the calf sneezes, Grandpa says, “She’s breathing!” The tag “called” and the exclamation point show he is excited and relieved.
p2_s1	What advice does Grandpa give Nadia?	**Stay calm and talk to Clover**	In paragraph 5, Grandpa says, “Just stay calm and talk to her.”
p2_s2	Which quote BEST shows that Nadia has changed by the end of the story?	**“She was brave enough to arrive in a snowstorm, and so was I.”**	At the end, Nadia calls herself brave. That is very different from her nervous whisper earlier, so this quote shows her change.

DIALOGUE DOES TWO JOBS (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
dc1_s0	Compare what Nadia says in paragraph 4 with what she says in paragraph 8. What change does her dialogue show?	**She goes from worried about making a mistake to proud and brave**	In paragraph 4 she whispers, “What if I do something wrong?” In paragraph 8 she says, “so was I” (brave). Comparing early and late dialogue reveals character change.
dc2_s0	Which line of dialogue sets the whole adventure in motion?	**“I think her calf is coming tonight.”**	Grandpa’s news that the calf is coming starts the plot. Everything else in the story happens because of it. Dialogue can move the plot forward.
dc1_s1	How are Nadia’s and Grandpa’s viewpoints different at the start of the night?	**Nadia worries she will make a mistake; Grandpa is calm and trusts her**	Nadia whispers, “What if I do something wrong?” Grandpa calmly says, “You know Clover better than anyone.” Their dialogue shows two different viewpoints.
dc2_s1	Grandpa jokes, “Calves don’t read calendars.” What does this dialogue show about his character?	**He stays calm and good-humored even in a stressful moment**	Making a gentle joke during an emergency shows Grandpa is calm and experienced. What a character says reveals what he is like.

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
dc1_s2	In the barn, Nadia tells Clover, “You’re okay, girl. We’re right here.” What does this dialogue show?	**She is following Grandpa’s advice and caring for Clover even though she was nervous**	Grandpa told her to stay calm and talk to Clover. Her gentle words show she is doing exactly that, which is the start of her change.
dc2_s2	Why does the author write that Nadia WHISPERED “What if I do something wrong?” instead of just “said”?	**“Whispered” shows that she feels scared and unsure**	A strong tag like “whispered” shows feeling. Nadia and Grandpa are still in the house, and strong tags should be used sparingly, so only the first choice is correct.

PUNCTUATION DETECTIVE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
pd1_s0	Find the mistakes! Which sentence is punctuated CORRECTLY?	**“Grab your boots,” Grandpa said.**	When the tag comes after the quote, a comma (not a period) ends the spoken words, and it goes INSIDE the closing quotation mark. Only Grandpa’s exact words go inside the quotation marks.
pd2_s0	The story says: “Tonight?” Nadia asked. Which explanation for why there is NO comma after “Tonight” is correct?	**The question mark takes the place of the comma, and it goes inside the closing quotation mark.**	A question mark or exclamation point replaces the comma. You never use both, and the end mark stays inside the quotation marks.
pd1_s1	Find the mistake! Sam wrote: Grandpa said, “you did great, Nadia.” What is wrong?	**The first word of the quote, “you,” should be capitalized.**	The first word of a quoted sentence always gets a capital letter: Grandpa said, “You did great, Nadia.”
pd2_s1	Paragraph 3 (“Calves don’t read calendars…”) starts a new paragraph right after Nadia speaks. Which explanation is correct?	**A new speaker, Grandpa, starts talking, so a new paragraph begins.**	Each time the speaker changes, start a new paragraph. Grandpa and Nadia are still in the house, so the setting did not change.
pd1_s2	Find the mistake! Which sentence is punctuated or capitalized INCORRECTLY?	**“We’re right here,” She said softly.**	When the tag comes after the quote, it continues the same sentence, so a pronoun like “she” stays lowercase: “We’re right here,” she said softly.
pd2_s2	A writer used these tags in one short scene: whispered, shouted, muttered, exclaimed, hollered, gasped. Which explanation is correct?	**Too many strong tags distract the reader. Use them sparingly and let “said” do most of the work.**	Strong tags are like spices: one or two add flavor, but too many get in the way. “Said” is almost invisible to readers, which is why it works so well.

FIX THE SENTENCE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
fs1_s0	Dialogue punctuation: add the quotation marks. Clover needs water, Grandpa said.	**"Clover needs water," Grandpa said.**	Quotation marks go around only Grandpa’s exact words, and the comma goes inside the closing quotation mark. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
fs2_s0	Capitalization: fix the two capital-letter mistakes. nadia asked, "is the calf awake?"	**Nadia asked, "Is the calf awake?"**	Names get capitals, and so does the first word of a quote. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs3_s0	Comma placement: add the missing comma. Grandpa said "The barn is warm."	**Grandpa said, "The barn is warm."**	When the tag comes first, put a comma after the tag, before the opening quotation mark. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs4_s0	Grammar: fix the its / it's mistake. The calf shook it's wet ears.	**The calf shook its wet ears.**	"It's" means "it is." The ears belong to the calf, so use the possessive "its" with no apostrophe. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs1_s1	Dialogue punctuation: add the missing end mark inside the quotation marks. "Is it snowing" Nadia asked.	**"Is it snowing?" Nadia asked.**	The quote is a question, so a question mark goes inside the closing quotation mark. It replaces the comma. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs2_s1	Capitalization: fix the two capital-letter mistakes. "the snow is deep," nadia said.	**"The snow is deep," Nadia said.**	The first word of the quote and the name Nadia both need capitals. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs3_s1	Comma placement: move the comma to the right spot. "Hold the towel", Nadia said.	**"Hold the towel," Nadia said.**	Commas and periods always go INSIDE the closing quotation mark. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs4_s1	Grammar: fix the run-on by making it two sentences. The wind howled the cows stayed warm in the barn.	**The wind howled. The cows stayed warm in the barn.**	Two complete thoughts were jammed together. End the first with a period and start the second with a capital letter. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs1_s2	Dialogue punctuation: add the quotation marks. Grandpa called, She's breathing!	**Grandpa called, "She's breathing!"**	Grandpa's exact words go inside quotation marks, and the exclamation point stays inside the closing quotation mark. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs2_s2	Capitalization: fix the three capital-letter mistakes. grandpa said, "let's check on clover."	**Grandpa said, "Let's check on Clover."**	Capitalize the first word of the sentence, the first word of the quote, and the name Clover. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
fs3_s2	Comma placement: add the missing comma. "It's a girl" Grandpa said with a smile.	**"It's a girl," Grandpa said with a smile.**	When the tag comes after the quote, a comma goes inside the closing quotation mark. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
fs4_s2	Grammar: fix the its / it's mistake. Its cold in the barn tonight.	**It's cold in the barn tonight.**	This sentence means "It is cold," so it needs the contraction "It's" with an apostrophe. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)

PUNCTUATE THE CONVERSATION (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
pc_s0	Nadia is speaking. Add capitals, a comma, quotation marks and an end mark. nadia whispered what if i do something wrong	**Nadia whispered, "What if I do something wrong?"**	Tag first, so a comma follows "whispered." Capitalize Nadia, What, and I. It is a question, so the question mark goes inside the closing quotation mark. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
pc_s1	Grandpa is speaking. Add capitals, a comma, quotation marks and an end mark. calves don't read calendars grandpa said	**"Calves don't read calendars," Grandpa said.**	Tag last, so the quote ends with a comma inside the closing quotation mark, and the whole sentence ends with a period after "said." Capitalize Calves and Grandpa. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)
pc_s2	Grandpa is speaking. Add capitals, a comma, quotation marks and an end mark. grandpa asked what should we name her	**Grandpa asked, "What should we name her?"**	Tag first, so a comma follows "asked." Capitalize Grandpa and What. It is a question, so the question mark goes inside the closing quotation mark. (Checked exactly; straight or curly quotes and extra spaces are OK.)

MATCH-UP ROUND (SETS 1–3, 2 POINTS EACH)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
m1_s0	Match: dialogue	**words characters say**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m2_s0	Match: quotation marks	**go around the exact words**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m3_s0	Match: dialogue tag	**tells who is speaking**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m4_s0	Match: speaker	**the character who is talking**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m5_s0	Match: new paragraph	**start one for each new speaker**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m1_s1	Match: strong tag	**a vivid verb like whispered**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m2_s1	Match: narrative	**a story with characters and events**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m3_s1	Match: comma	**separates the tag from the quote**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m4_s1	Match: question mark	**ends a quote that asks something**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
m5_s1	Match: character change	**how a character is different at the end**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m1_s2	Match: viewpoint	**how a character sees things**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m2_s2	Match: dialogue tag	**tells who is speaking**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m3_s2	Match: quotation marks	**go around the exact words**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m4_s2	Match: end mark	**period, question mark, or exclamation point**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).
m5_s2	Match: strong tag	**a vivid verb like whispered**	2 points per first-try match (10 per set).

BOSS CHALLENGE (SETS 1–3)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
b1_s0	Each paragraph is labeled. Which conversation is written CORRECTLY?	**Paragraph 1: “Is she okay?” Nadia asked. / Paragraph 2: “She’s perfect,” Grandpa said.**	Choice 1 gives each speaker a new paragraph, keeps the question mark inside the quotes, uses a comma before “Grandpa said,” and capitalizes “She’s.” Each other choice breaks at least one rule.
b2_s0	Two-step: Ella wrote grandpa said "the calf is here". Which list names ALL of her mistakes?	**Capitalize Grandpa, add a comma after said, capitalize The, and move the period inside the quotation mark**	Correct: Grandpa said, “The calf is here.” That fixes four things: the capital at the start, the comma after the tag, the capital at the start of the quote, and the period inside the closing quotation mark.
b1_s1	Look at this sentence: “I’m so proud of you,” Grandpa said. Why is there a COMMA, not a period, after “you”? Which explanation is correct?	**The sentence keeps going with the dialogue tag, so a comma ends a quote that asks something instead of a period.**	A period would end the sentence too early. The tag “Grandpa said” finishes the sentence, so the spoken part ends with a comma tucked inside the closing quotation mark.
b2_s1	Two-step: Marco wrote nadia asked "can i help" Which list names ALL of his mistakes?	**Capitalize Nadia, add a comma after asked, capitalize Can and I, and add a question mark inside the closing quotation mark**	Correct: Nadia asked, “Can I help?” That is five fixes: the name, the comma after the tag, the capitals Can and I, and the question mark inside the quotation marks.
b1_s2	Each paragraph is labeled. Which conversation is written CORRECTLY?	**Paragraph 1: “The wind is so loud!” Nadia said. / Paragraph 2: “Then let’s sing to Clover,” Grandpa said.**	Choice 1 starts a new paragraph for Grandpa, keeps the exclamation point inside the quotes, and capitalizes “Then.” Each other choice breaks at least one rule.

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
b2_s2	Two-step: Jada wrote "Grab the towel"! grandpa shouted. Which list names ALL of her mistakes?	**Move the exclamation point inside the quotation mark and capitalize Grandpa**	Correct: “Grab the towel!” Grandpa shouted. The exclamation point belongs to the spoken words, so it goes inside, and Grandpa is used as a name, so it gets a capital.

SPEED TRAIL (BONUS XP ONLY, NOT SCORED)

ID	Question	Answer	Why (explain to student)
tt1	Where does the comma go? “Let’s go” Nadia said.	**Inside the closing quotation mark**	Commas go inside the closing quotation mark: “Let’s go,” Nadia said.
tt2	A new character starts talking. What do you do?	**Start a new paragraph**	Every new speaker gets a new paragraph.
tt3	Which word needs a capital? Nadia said, “the calf is here.”	**the**	The first word of a quote is capitalized: “The calf is here.”

Pre & Post sheet answer guide

Many items are open-ended. Grade for genuine understanding and complete sentences, not exact wording.

PRE-LESSON WARM-UP

#	Prompt	Model answer / grading note
1	Add quotation marks: Grandpa said, The barn is warm.	Grandpa said, "The barn is warm."
2	Which sentence is punctuated correctly?	"Grab your boots," Grandpa said. (comma inside the closing quotation mark)
3	Fix capitals: nadia said, "the snow is deep."	Nadia said, "The snow is deep."
4	Add the missing comma.	"Let's feed the calves," Nadia said.
5	Review: "I can't do this" to "I did it!"	Character change

POST-LESSON CHALLENGE

#	Prompt	Model answer / grading note
1	grandpa asked is clover okay	Grandpa asked, "Is Clover okay?"
2	Fix two mistakes: "we did it", Nadia shouted.	"We did it," Nadia shouted. (Capital W; comma moves inside the quotation mark. Also accept "We did it!" Nadia shouted.)
3	Split into two paragraphs.	Line 1: "Is the calf warm?" Nadia asked. New paragraph: "Warm as toast," Grandpa said.
4	Which tag fits trying not to wake the calf?	whispered
5	Write 4 lines of dialogue (Nadia and Grandpa, next morning).	Grading note: look for quotation marks around exact words only; a tag-before line with a comma after the tag; a tag-after line with a comma or end mark inside the closing quote; capital first word in each quote; a new paragraph for each speaker; at least one line that shows a feeling. Sample: "Good morning, Blizzard!" Nadia called. / Grandpa laughed and said, "She's already trying to run." / "Can I feed her first?" Nadia asked. / "She's all yours," Grandpa said.

★ CHALLENGE

#	Prompt	Model answer / grading note
1	Two characters disagree (6 to 8 lines).	Grading note: each character's viewpoint is clear from what they say; new paragraph for each speaker; correct quotation marks, commas, capitals and end marks; exactly one strong tag. Praise dialogue that also moves the plot.